

SFPA Spring 2026 City Championship

Title Odds — Tournament Projection

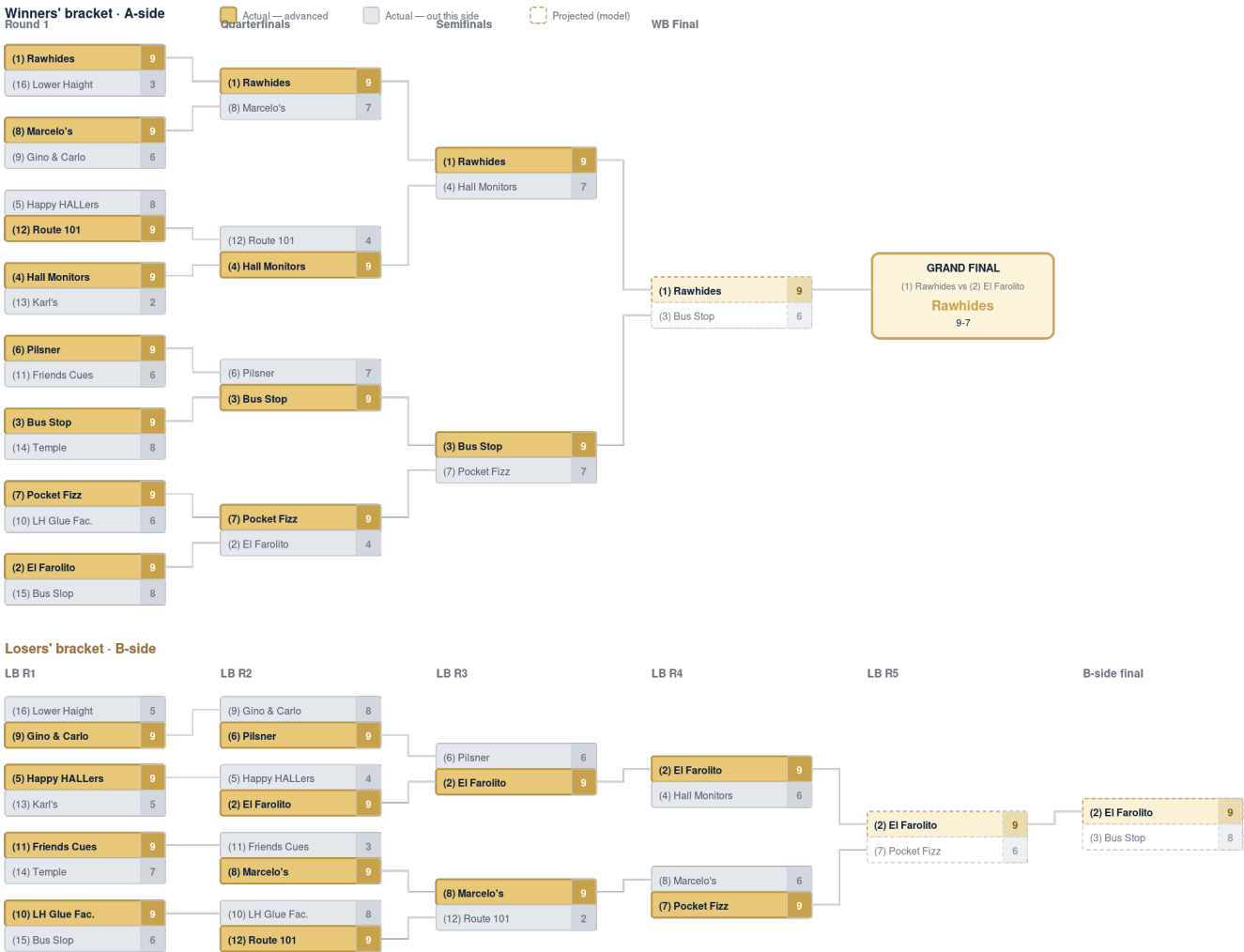
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Rawhides are the favorite to win the City Championship at **79%**, ahead of a tight chase between **Bus Stop** (15%) and **El Farolito** (6%). Together the top three hold about 100% of all title equity; below them the field falls off sharply.

Team	Seed	Title %	Reach Grand Final
Happy Lounge Rawhides	1	79.2%	93%
Bus Stop Flyers	3	14.9%	61%
El Farolito Shooters	2	5.7%	39%
Pocket Full of Fizz	7	0.2%	7%
Hall Monitors	4	0.0%	0%
Happy HALLers	5	0.0%	0%
Pilsner InnDecisives	6	0.0%	0%
Marcelo's Hall Stars	8	0.0%	0%
Gino & Carlo	9	0.0%	0%
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	10	0.0%	0%
Friends Crooked Cues	11	0.0%	0%
Route 101 Dalmatians	12	0.0%	0%
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	13	0.0%	0%
Temple Holy Smokes	14	0.0%	0%
Bus Slop	15	0.0%	0%
Lower Haight Misfits	16	0.0%	0%

Projected Bracket

Single most-likely path through the 16-team double elimination. Lose on the A-side (winners') and you drop to the B-side (losers'); a second loss ends your run. The B-side survivor must beat the A-side finalist twice. **Grand Final:** (1) Rawhides vs (2) El Farolito — champion **Rawhides** (9-7).



The state of play

For all the model's confidence in the favorite, this has been the opposite of a chalk tournament. Rawhides have held up their end — still a commanding **79.2%** to win it — but everything behind them has been chaos: a #2 seed knocked out early, the six-season Pilsner dynasty gone, a 12-seed Cinderella in Route 101, and a 7-seed in Pocket Fizz that flatly refuses to read the seed lines. With the field down to **4**, the bracket has split into two very different movies.

On the A-side it's coronation-or-spoiler: **Rawhides sit one win from the hot seat**, with only Bus Stop in the way — and four seasons of history saying Rawhides own that matchup when it counts (**5-1** all-time, and a perfect **2-0** in the playoffs). On the B-side it's a survival gauntlet: **El Farolito**, the fallen 2-seed, is trying to claw all the way back — and runs straight into **Pocket Fizz**, the very team that knocked them down in the first place. A revenge rematch with a season on the line.

What keeps it tense even with a heavy favorite is the double-elimination math. Rawhides need just two wins and carry a safety net at every step; whoever emerges from the losers' bracket has to run the table and then beat the A-side finalist *twice*. Two wins with insurance versus five must-wins through a gauntlet — that asymmetry is the whole tournament in a sentence. For the trophy to change hands, somebody's long shot has to hit.

Special Thursday Update

A quiet Thursday it was not. Two losers'-bracket matches, two nine-game escapes, and by the end of the night the B-side had been cut in half — with the tournament's two most improbable survivors set on a collision course nobody would have drawn up in week one.

Start with the shocker. Pocket Fizz — the 7-seed that already bounced #2 El Farolito out of the winners' bracket — did it again, knocking off Marcelo's 9-6 to keep the Cinderella run alive. The engine room was **Roy Santiago**: the 616-rated ace went a perfect **4-0** and slammed the door himself, taking the deciding rack over Willie Gregory. Marcelo's, meanwhile, got nothing from the top of their order — **Ben Green went 0-4**, four games and four losses, a rare blank line from a contender's board — and it cost them their season.

The other match was pure heart. El Farolito outlasted Hall Monitors 9-6 in a grind, and the storybook finish belonged to their unlikeliest hero: with the match on the line, **434-rated Sayda Soto — the lowest-rated player on the table** — stepped up and won the clinching game over Hall Monitors' Clancy Green (540), a hundred-plus-point underdog delivering the biggest rack of the night. The 2-seed didn't win it with their stars on Thursday; they won it because their bottom rung held.

Two heavyweights went home — **Marcelo's and Hall Monitors are eliminated**, and the field is down to four. The board noticed. Rewarded for surviving *and* handed the softer of the two remaining B-side paths, **El Farolito's title odds more than doubled, from 2.6% to 5.7%**, and their chance of reaching the grand final now sits near **39%**. Pocket Fizz tick up too, though the model still sees the mountain in front of them at 0.2%.

And now the bracket serves up its spiciest leftover: **El Farolito vs Pocket Fizz**, win or go home, for the right to reach the B-side final. It's the rematch of the quarterfinal stunner — the 2-seed that Pocket Fizz already sent packing once, now with a season riding on the do-over. If Roy Santiago and the 7-seed can drop another established heavyweight, this stops being a fluke and starts being a run.

Last Week: Winners' Bracket Semifinals + Losers' Bracket R3

Rawhides stay the favorite, holding at 79.2% (from 79.5% a week ago) — but underneath them, plenty moved.

They got there by booking the winners'-bracket final: Rawhides beat Hall Monitors 9-7 and Bus Stop beat Pocket Fizz 9-7. The A-side title match is set — Rawhides vs Bus Stop — and it carries a double-elimination twist: the winner walks into the grand final with a safety net (the losers'-bracket survivor has to beat them twice), while the loser is knocked to the one-loss side. Bus Stop climbed to 14.9% as the second-most-likely champion — distant, but real.

The night's gut-punch landed on the losers' side — and it was the end of an era. El Farolito ended Pilsner's season 9-6, and with it one of the great runs in City Championship history. For six-plus seasons the InnDecisives never fell out of the top two; their all-time playoff record is 17-7, and the number that defined the dynasty is 15-0 — their mark against everyone who wasn't the Rawhides. For years you did not beat Pilsner. Rawhides beat Pilsner, and nobody else got a turn.

This was supposed to be the redemption year. Evan Burgess, their 576-rated ace, had spent the first half of the season playing down with a junior team as its coach — he was always coming back for the playoffs, and it was his absence from the standings, not from the roster, that stuck a team this good with the 6-seed. He returned, the lineup was whole, and for a while the old magic held. But here is the cruelest detail: for the first time anyone can remember, Pilsner's season didn't end against Rawhides. They fell one rung short of even reaching the rival the whole bracket was bending toward. Six seasons of inevitability, gone quietly in the one-loss bracket. Pour one out for the InnDecisives.

There was a Cinderella in the wreckage, too, and midnight finally came: Marcelo's ended Route 101's run 9-2. But what a run it was. The 12th-seed Dalmatians knocked off a top seed in the opening round and then flat refused to lose a close one — both of their wins were 9-8 heart-stoppers that made the smart money sweat for weeks. The glass slipper doesn't fit anymore, but the Dalmatians danced a lot longer than a 12th seed has any right to.

Also out on a second loss: Hall Monitors. Pocket Fizz survive but drop to the losers' bracket, where one more slip ends it. 4 teams remain. For Rawhides, only the winners'-bracket final stands between them and the grand final.

Result	Model predicted	Actual
(1) Rawhides def. (4) Hall Monitors	Rawhides 9-7	9-7
(3) Bus Stop def. (7) Pocket Fizz	Bus Stop 9-7	9-7
(2) El Farolito def. (6) Pilsner — beat the pick	Pilsner 9-8	9-6
(8) Marcelo's def. (12) Route 101	Marcelo's 9-5	9-2

Model-predicted score (favorite and expected margin) vs. the actual result. Shaded rows mark a match the model's pick lost; winner's game count shown first.

Looking Ahead

The hot seat — Rawhides vs Bus Stop

The one everybody's tuning in for. The winners'-bracket final decides who takes the hot seat: a ticket straight to the grand final with the double-elimination cushion that makes a team nearly impossible to dislodge. The loser doesn't go home, but drops to the one-loss side and inherits the long gauntlet back. Win here and you're most of the way to a title; lose and the mountain triples.

And these two have history. Over the last four seasons plus this year's regular season, Rawhides and Bus Stop have met 6 times — and Rawhides have won 5 of them, taking 63% of all the games played between the two clubs. Bus Stop's lone win came on a regular-season night; when the playoff lights come on it hasn't been close, with Rawhides a perfect 2-0 in the postseason and 75% of those games (18-6).

On Fargo alone the model makes Rawhides a 75% pick for the match (a 58% edge per game). Layer in the head-to-head — the fact that Bus Stop has never solved this specific opponent when it mattered — and the number climbs toward 85%. Ratings and receipts point the same way. Bus Stop's path to the upset is real but narrow: they've hung big game counts on Rawhides before, so the talent to make it a match is there — they just have to finally close one on the big stage.

Win or go home — El Farolito vs Pocket Fizz

A quieter but no-less-tense elimination game. El Farolito (the 2-seed and the field's hottest regular-season form team) meet Pocket Fizz (the 7-seed that stunned El Farolito in the quarterfinals), and the model gives El Farolito a clear edge — 75% for the match on a 58% per-game advantage (effective Fargo 569 to 521). Both teams already carry a loss, so this one is simple: the winner plays on, the loser's playoff is over. But seeds have already meant little in this bracket, and one hot night flips it.

Playoff Standouts

The bracket is a team game, but somebody has to make the balls. A look at who's carrying the load for the teams still standing — the players quietly (and not so quietly) winning their matches within the match.

Standout of the round

No one has been better with the season on the line. Steven Waldon has gone **7-1** in the playoffs — a **88%** win rate, the best of any regular still standing — and this week he went **4-0 with a table run**, closing out the winners'-bracket semifinal himself with the deciding rack over Hall Monitors' Clancy Green to send Rawhides to the final. That's the Waldon pattern: he ran the table a league-leading count of times this season, and his playoff table-run consistency is the stuff of local legend. If the grand final ever comes down to a single deciding game, he's exactly who the Rawhides want stepping to the table.

Player	Team	Playoff W-L	Win %	Table runs
Steven Waldon	Rawhides	7-1	88%	1
Albert Yip	Pocket Fizz	6-1	86%	—
Wade Hargrove	Bus Stop	6-2	75%	—
Tom Purcell	Bus Stop	8-4	67%	—
Bob Simon	Rawhides	7-4	64%	1
Otoniel Jimenez	El Farolito	9-6	60%	2
Perez Vallarta	El Farolito	7-5	58%	1
Kevin Scheper	Rawhides	6-5	55%	—

Individual game record across the playoff weeks, for players on teams still alive (min. 6 games). Table runs = racks won from the break without the opponent reaching the table.

Hottest hands this week: Steven Waldon (Rawhides) 4-0 [table run]; **Perez Vallarta** (El Farolito) 4-0 [table run].

Playoff Performance Ratings

A performance rating answers a different question than a win-loss record: *how good did you actually play?* We take every individual game a player played this playoff run, look up each opponent's Fargo, and solve for the rating at which their win total is exactly what you'd expect. Beat a 500-rated player at a 4-2 clip and you performed like a 600. It rewards beating strong opponents and doesn't punish anyone for a tough draw — the ultimate opponent-adjusted scoreboard.

Top performer — 833

And nobody in the tournament has played at a higher level than **Steven Waldon**. Against playoff competition averaging **549** Fargo, his 7-1 run computes to an **833 performance rating** — a staggering **+229 over his own 604 rating**, and the single highest performance mark of anyone in the field (the next-best is 743). Put plainly: a very good 604-rated player spent the playoffs playing like an elite 800+. That's not a hot streak against soft competition — his opponents averaged 549 — it's the best pool anyone in this City Championship has played.

Player	Team	W-L	Avg opp	Fargo	Performance	vs rating
Steven Waldon	Rawhides	7-1	549	604	833	+229
Albert Yip	Pocket Fizz	6-1	468	487	743	+256
Khanh Ngo	Marcelo's	8-2	521	583	730	+147
Prithiv Kumar	Hall Monitors	9-2	487	544	719	+175
Antonio Cracchiolo	Hall Monitors	8-2	492	578	707	+129
Wade Hargrove	Bus Stop	6-2	508	552	677	+125
Willie Gregory	Marcelo's	5-2	478	561	616	+55
Tom Purcell	Bus Stop	8-4	505	515	610	+95
Nithin Tharakan	Marcelo's	9-5	512	525	601	+76
Bob Simon	Rawhides	7-4	505	543	591	+48
Otoniel Jimenez	El Farolito	9-6	490	627	553	-74
Perez Vallarta	El Farolito	7-5	487	537	543	+6

Performance = the Fargo level a player performed at across the playoffs, from opponent-weighted results (players on teams still alive, min. 6 games). "vs rating" is performance minus their own Fargo.

Team Elo — Overall Strength

Each team's strength rating: the Fargo of their best playoff lineup, adjusted for season form, plus a data-tested pedigree where earned. Higher = stronger. This is what drives the title odds.

Rank	Team	Team Elo	Top-4 Fargo	Title %
1	Happy Lounge Rawhides	1702	609.5	79.2%
2	Pilsner InnDecisives	1632	539.0	0.0%
3	Hall Monitors	1620	567.0	0.0%
4	El Farolito Shooters	1605	548.0	5.7%
5	Marcelo's Hall Stars	1598	553.8	0.0%
6	Bus Stop Flyers	1594	550.5	14.9%
7	Pocket Full of Fizz	1526	515.0	0.2%
8	Happy HALLers	1509	503.8	0.0%
9	Temple Holy Smokes	1508	513.2	0.0%
10	Gino & Carlo	1502	505.2	0.0%
11	Friends Crooked Cues	1454	478.0	0.0%
12	Route 101 Dalmatians	1412	455.8	0.0%
13	Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	1401	453.8	0.0%
14	Bus Slop	1378	443.2	0.0%
15	Karl's Freakin' Beacon	1363	431.8	0.0%
16	Lower Haight Misfits	1317	409.8	0.0%

How These Numbers Were Built

1. A rating based on who actually plays. Each team is rated by its players' Fargo (skill) ratings — but performance is judged against the lineup it *actually fielded* each match, not its best-case roster. If a team rests a star or plays a weaker substitute who performs at their own level, the model doesn't punish them: it expected less, and got it. When a 405-rated depth player loses most of his games to 600-rated opponents, that's neutral, not a black mark. Most rating systems can't tell "played badly" from "fielded a weaker lineup" — this one can, because it reads every individual player's result in every match.

2. Win probabilities — and proof they work. Playoff matches are a race to 9 (a 9-3 match ends after 12 games). The Fargo gap between the two lineups sets each game's odds, capped at 75/25 since pool has too much variance for locks; at 8-8 a single deciding game is played between each team's top player. We back-tested the engine on this season: it correctly called **76.5% of 251 matches** (Brier score 0.154), with well-calibrated confidence — the basis for trusting the odds.

3. 60,000 simulated tournaments. The full double-elimination bracket is played 60,000 times; every number in this report — the title odds and the projected bracket — comes from that one simulation, so they're mutually consistent.

4. A data-tested pedigree for Pilsner. Rather than guess at a "dynasty" weight, we tested it: across four seasons of playoff results, Pilsner's record is 4-season playoff record 17-7 (71%), and every loss came against Rawhides — against everyone else they are a perfect 15-0. That overperformance is statistically real ($p < 0.05$), so Pilsner carries a measured +30 Fargo playoff bump. No other team earned one; Rawhides' four titles are the best team doing what it should, already in its rating.

Every adjustment has a number behind it, not a feel. Pool is high-variance — treat these as probabilities, not predictions; even a clear favorite loses far more often than it wins.

Appendix — Season Form

A supporting metric, not a strength rating: did a team beat or miss its own roster's Fargo expectation this season, match by match? A strong team can show negative form if it underplayed its talent.

Team	Season Form	vs roster
El Farolito Shooters	+28.0	overachieved
Happy HALLers	+17.2	overachieved
Route 101 Dalmatians	+14.4	overachieved
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	+13.9	overachieved
Friends Crooked Cues	+11.6	overachieved
Lower Haight Misfits	+10.8	overachieved
Pocket Full of Fizz	+8.1	overachieved
Pilsner InnDecisives	+4.9	~ as expected
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	+4.0	~ as expected
Bus Stop Flyers	+3.5	~ as expected
Gino & Carlo	+2.4	~ as expected
Bus Slop	+1.6	~ as expected
Marcelo's Hall Stars	+0.1	~ as expected
Hall Monitors	-7.3	underachieved
Happy Lounge Rawhides	-10.4	underachieved

Team	Season Form	vs roster
Temple Holy Smokes	-13.5	underachieved